

select Properties, and click on the Security tab. You can configure the access rights for users and folders from this tab.

2.4. Use user accounts and passwords

Assign user accounts and passwords to all regular users of your computer. Individual user accounts not only enables Windows XP to personalise settings for each user, it also enables one to control what users can access on the system. Thus, normal users will be unable to delete or change critical system files. Also, a good security practice is never to use blank passwords: that is an open invitation to attackers.

As a rule, if you are the primary user of your computer, set up two accounts for yourself: an Administrator account and a regular (limited) user account. Running your computer in Administrator mode and connecting to the Internet is a potential security risk, as Trojans or viruses that manage to enter the system will have complete access to the system with Administrator privileges. These malicious software can then wreak havoc on the system: they could format the hard disk, delete important system files, and so on.

If you require to do any system administration tasks like upgrading the system or changing the system configuration, log off from your regular user account and log back in as Administrator.

Assuming your computer is not part of a domain, log in to your computer as Administrator and go to *Control Panel > User Accounts*. The Administrator account allows you to do the following:

- Create and delete user accounts
- Create passwords for other accounts
- Change account names, pictures, passwords and account types